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Multimodality and the Multiliteracies Pedagogy: "Design" and "Recruitment" in South African Children's Musical Games

Susan Harrop-Allin[1]

Abstract

Drawing on a study of children's musical games in urban South Africa, this article employs two theoretical frames: that of multimodality and the multiliteracies pedagogy. These are applied to a contextual analysis of the forms of musicality that musical games embody and to ways of incorporating children's play into pedagogy. Based on ethnographic research in primary schools in Soweto, I first examine representative examples of musical games in order to demonstrate children's musicianship in relation to the concept of multimodality. Analysis reveals the games' sophistication in terms of children's deployment of multiple modes and the inventiveness their methods imply. Furthermore, a multimodal theoretical frame and analytical approach enables an understanding of musicality as the capacity to "design." Second, children's multimodal musicality prompts questions about how such musicality may become a resource in formal learning. I propose that applying the multiliteracies pedagogy to music education offers a methodological solution for "recruiting" musical games so that the capacities children demonstrate in their games may be developed.

Keywords

multimodality, multiliteracies pedagogy, children's musical games, South Africa, urban township, Soweto, semiotic resources, design

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Dum dum dare, dum dum dawalawala
See see clair, see see dawalawala
Iny meeny aca – iny meeny air
Oogabooga, oogabooga oogabooga
SPLAT

I made the game up myself and I asked my friends for some words. Then I put it with a tune I heard [a fragment sourced from the well-known clapping game, *Down Down Baby*] and used another clapping game I know that has the elimination part in it. So I put together bits and pieces of ideas from all over the place. Then I taught it to my friends. (Jessica, London, 2015)

Valuing Musical Play in Music Education

Creating a clapping game and song by "using bits and pieces from all over the place" is characteristic of the ways children compose and play musical games all over the world (see, e.g., Bishop & Burn, 2013; Campbell, 2010; Countryman, 2014; Harwood & Marsh, 2012; K. Marsh, 2008; K. Marsh & Young, 2006). The striking similarity between the ways children I have observed in London and South Africa compose, play, and play *with* musical games tallies with the previously cited research findings, suggesting that all children are intuitively musical within playground communities. The musicality at work here deserves the attention of music educators as it embodies inventive compositional strategies and abilities that can potentially alter pedagogy in constructive ways.

The question of how and why to transfer children's musical learning from outside to inside the classroom is of particular concern in music education research. The major work on bringing what often is referred to as "informal" musical learning into classrooms focuses mainly on teenagers and popular music learning (Green, 2002, 2005, 2008). For younger children, the most relevant work is on musical play, recognized internationally as an important site of musical learning that operates within the contexts of children's cultural and social worlds. As children's musical cultures embody their musical identities and potential, the necessity to relate children's musical practices to formal learning also is argued for in a wide body of research.[1] In her extensive study of children's musical games and chants, Kathryn Marsh (2008), for example, gives valuable recommendations for developing pedagogies that develop the capacities children display in their musical games. Harwood and Marsh (2012) further offer suggestions for implementing understandings of children's musical play within a curricular context, utilizing demonstrated game skills and attributes for further musical development. Appreciating the value of musical play and informal musical learning more broadly has impacted classroom teaching and learning; "play has become an integral part of curriculum and [is] being integrated into educational efforts in many nations" (Lew & Campbell, 2005, p. 58).

In Southern African music education, Mans (2002, 2003) and Kreutzer (1995, 2001) emphasize the significance of "indigenous" musical play, suggesting that music

curricula be based on the "musicality children already possess and which encourages them to move into a wider musical world" (Kreutzer, 1995, p. 65). However, there is relatively little research on how children's musical games can be used as resources for pedagogic purposes in South African classrooms or investigating the distinctive types of cultural and musical hybridity that characterize South African children's lives. Working with teachers in urban and rural primary schools, it became clear that musical play was disconnected from formal learning and that informal musical learning in general had little bearing on teaching in many South African schools.

In keeping with informal musical learning research (Green, 2002, 2005, 2008), the central issue here is how to bring children's musical learning from outside to inside the classroom and developing pedagogy for doing so. To address this question, it was essential to first gain "a thorough knowledge of the nature and extent of children's musical play" (Lum & Campbell, 2007, p. 32).

Rationale and Purpose

This article draws from a larger ethnographic study of children's musical games in three Soweto primary schools, followed by case study research that trialed a new pedagogy based on the games' analysis and interpretation. For this article, I focused on a representative sample of 4 out of 30 games I originally documented, examining them to identify the ingredients of children's musicality in this context. The research is grounded on a conception of children's musical games as situated practices that are socially and culturally constituted. Thus, I focus on how a multimodal framework (Jewitt, 2013; Jewitt & Kress, 2003; Kress, 2000c, 2010) draws attention to aspects of local musical knowledge and innovative practices associated with the South African urban township while also alluding to global features of musical play. Hence, in this article I bring a multimodal lens to the games as an interpretive, analytical strategy to identify the kind of "work" operating here and then to suggest ways of building on these insights to move beyond reiteration and into pedagogy. Based on insights gained through multimodal analysis, I then examined the issues in relation to the multiliteracies pedagogy (New London Group, 2000). I propose a methodology of "recruitment" that develops the musicianship children demonstrate in their playground play.

Perspectives of Musical Play Research

Structural anthropologist John Blacking (1967) is credited with the inaugural work that studied children's music cultures as separate and autonomous from adult music. His seminal ethnomusicological study in South Africa's northern Limpopo Province is significant for its contribution to a culturally contextual understanding of the forms and functions of children's music and still is drawn on in contemporary work (e.g., Campbell & Wiggins, 2013; Emberly, 2013; Gaunt, 2006; Harwood & Marsh, 2012). Since Blacking, children's musicking has been studied from many perspectives: as part of folkloric, oral traditions (Factor, 1998, 2001; Opie & Opie, 1985/1988; Sutton-Smith, 1976); culturally specific "expressive practices" (Minks, 2002); and practices

tied to identity, gender, communication, and sociality (Gaunt, 2006; Grugeon, 1993; Merrill-Mirsky, 1988; Minks, 2013).

A further body of work recognizes musical play as an essential area of study for understanding children's informal musical learning (Barrett, 2005; Harwood, 1998; K. Marsh & Young, 2006). Contemporary studies have shifted the focus to the compositional and learning processes in children's spontaneous and self-motivated music-making, and these have in turn informed music education (Campbell, 2010; Harwood & Marsh, 2012; K. Marsh, 1995, 2008).

Documenting children's music as context-specific practices necessitates research methodologies that can describe its situated nature. Hence, a strong body of work for musical games research is done in the ethnographic tradition. These studies have the advantage of yielding data that demonstrate social and cultural particularities (Countryman, 2014; Lum, 2007; Lum & Campbell, 2007; J. Marsh & Richards, 2013; K. Marsh, 2008, 2009; Minks, 2013). Whereas folklore studies tend to view games and songs as fixed texts, ethnomusicological studies view music "as a changing rather than a static phenomenon" (K. Marsh, 2008, p. 17). Recognizing change in relation to the influence of popular music, dance, and the media enables researchers to document the intricacies of musical games (Bishop & Burn, 2013; Burn, 2014; Harwood, 1994; J. Marsh & Richards, 2013; K. Marsh, 1999, 2001).

Major contributions to the field are from Kathryn Marsh (2008), who investigates tensions between "continuity and change" and universal versus contextually unique features of musical play. Addressing similar issues, folklorist June Factor (1988) describes the local–global nature of musical games as "a double helix, one strand representing the universal, ubiquitous features of childlore, the other the particular manifestations of children's play lives which result from specific circumstances" (p. xiv). As will be shown, while each game is local in relation to the South African urban context under study, there are elements that connect them to the attributes of children's musical games globally, consistent with "the universality of children's engagement with music" (Campbell & Wiggins, 2013, p. 2; also see Boynton & Kok, 2006).

Examining Musical Play in African Contexts

Despite this range, however, "most descriptions of children's musical play are historically anchored within the worlds of North American and European children" (Lew & Campbell, 2005, p. 58). It is acknowledged that "the literature is limited when considering other cultures and social classes" (Lew & Campbell, 2005, p. 58) and that "studies of childhood music have been restricted to the developed world" (K. Marsh & Young, 2006, p. 291).

When undertaken in "undeveloped" Africa, for example, research tends to focus on rural areas and characterize children's music as "indigenous," associated with past traditions assumed to be untouched by outside influences (Addo, 1997; Akuno, 1997; Kreutzer, 2001; Mapana, 2011). Allied to this is a propensity to adopt a hermetic view of culture, where children learn "the essential characteristics of the music of their culture"

(Campbell, 2006, p. 427) and ethnic groups are assumed to be distinct (Makina, 2009; Nyota & Mapara, 2008; Roux, 2006). Such studies may display a set of assumptions about the nature of cultures that limits the researcher's interest in expressing what is contextually specific.

Even in areas associated with more homogenous cultures, however, recent research on Venda children's music in Limpopo Province, South Africa (Emberly, 2013); Miskitu children's music on a Nicaraguan island (Minks, 2013); and in urban Gambia (Koops, 2010, 2013) acknowledge that categories of traditional and modern are contested. These provide a more diverse view of children's musical play in both rural and urban contexts, allowing a nuanced conception of cultural processes and transmission.

Complex cultural practices are typical of urban contexts, and previous research emphasizes the "necessity to unravel the particularities of children's musical lives in [an] urban locale" (Lum, 2009, p. 28), especially in non-Western countries. As children's musicking arises from individual sets of circumstance (Bishop & Burn, 2013), accounting for context is essential.

Research Context

The Richness of Township Culture

This research responds to the need for recognizing and documenting children's musicking in culturally, linguistically, and socially heterogeneous African urban areas, such as Soweto—South Africa's largest urban township.[2] Like other townships, Soweto is characterized by an amalgamation of traditional and contemporary cultural practices, languages, ethnicities, and nationalities. What binds Black urban South African communities together is what is termed *loxion kultcha*: a conglomeration of slang and gestural languages, visual styles, township music, and dance (as described in Allen, 2004; Bogatsu, 2002; Coplan, 2007).[3] Integral to *loxion kultcha* is its unique communicative, expressive, and artistic practices: the "slang" and gestural language of *scamto*,[4] *kwaito*, hip-hop, and South Africa's brand of house music.[5] On streets and school playgrounds, children integrate elements that epitomize young urban township culture into their musical play.

The Poverty of Learning: South African Music and Arts Education

The differences between the richness of children's musical games in township and rural school playgrounds and the relative poverty of education they receive in the classroom are stark.[6] This makes the ubiquity and complexity of children's playground musical play all the more striking: Children's resourcefulness and the creativity demonstrated in their games contrast with the generally poor quality of music and arts education in many South African schools (discussed in Herbst, De Wet, & Rijsdijk, 2005; also see Harrop-Allin, 2010). The disjuncture between playgrounds and classrooms in many township schools is emblematic of a wider set of problems and contradictions in South African music education (Harrop-Allin, 2011). A failure to connect

the everyday uses of music to conceptions of musical knowledge or recognize music-making as an active endeavor instead of a passive one makes meaningful music education difficult to achieve. Although music is integrated into the fabric of South African social and religious life (especially for Black South Africans), the informal teaching and learning that epitomizes this musicking is seldom connected to formal education.

This is partly the case because epistemological misconceptions are articulated in South Africa's third postapartheid national curriculum (Department of Basic Education, 2011). Although the subject "Creative and Performing Arts" includes diverse musics, it is based on a conception of musical knowledge as a written literacy. Learning staff notation, Western harmony, and form is at odds with the philosophy, learning processes, and performance of much African and popular musics that are included in the policy documents (Carver, 2002). In several African countries, staff notation–based music education curricula are still the norm and widely critiqued (Akrofi, 2007; Chirwa & Naidoo, 2014; Harrop-Allin & Kros, 2014; Herbst, 2007). The disparities between the vibrancy of township children's playground music and lack of active music-making in the arts and culture classes I observed prompted this research, which aimed to bridge the playground and classroom as sites of practice.

Research Design and Methods

This article draws from a larger study of children's musical games that connected them pedagogically to classroom practice (Harrop-Allin, 2010). Methodologically, I drew on K. Marsh's (2008) approach in *The Musical Playground*, which was to document, describe, and analyze children's musical games as a prerequisite for considering their relationship to formal teaching and learning.

The research took place at three Soweto primary schools with children aged between 9 and 13 years. All students were Black and spoke a range and mixture of South African languages, including township *scamto* slang.[7] I employed an ethnographic research design in order to facilitate an engagement with music-making in its social and performance context and an understanding of musical games as situated, local practices.

During fieldwork undertaken over 6 months, I used "field observation—directly observing and recording without interacting" (McMillan & Schumacher, 2006, p. 346). I gained permission to document children's playground games and established my role as researcher and teacher-educator.[8] Fieldwork data collection methods included visual, aural, and written documentation. In conjunction with observation, I held informal interviews with teachers and unstructured informal interviews with children in focus groups after their playground performances, which were used for "exploratory purposes" (Merriam, 1998). However, interviews were not the main source of data collection as the focus was on the performative nature of children's games. Furthermore, it was difficult to elicit verbal responses from learners about their games, partially because of a language barrier, but mainly because their musical games function in terms of nonverbal meaning. Hence, video recordings formed the primary

data for description, analysis, and interpretation. Assisted by teachers, learners, and older students, I transcribed the song and chant texts, accompanying clapping patterns, actions, and dance formations.

Each game described here was video recorded several times so that each description represents an amalgamation of several performances that varied in each instance. What was particularly fascinating was the constant variation and adjustment of different parameters each time children practiced their games, depending on which grouping of children played the game, and their levels of expertise.

Interpretation and Analysis

Much of the semantic meaning and references in Soweto children's games are internal to their play and social groups and were therefore inaccessible to me. The children's teachers also struggled at times to grasp the meanings of the local slang, invented words, and gestures or the origins of appropriated musical ideas. Children incorporate aspects of township communicative, linguistic practices, including code-switching, to produce multilayered, intertextural performances.[9] The video recordings were observed and interpreted many times by seven "cultural insiders"—older students who grew up in Soweto and other townships who had played similar games as children and were familiar with allusions to *loxion kultcha*. This triangulation of data as a form of "cross-validation" aimed to ensure descriptive and analytic depth (McMillan & Schumacher, 2006, p. 374). Multiple observations, conversations, and interpretations of the same games by different informants also obviated the problems of a single representation of the games by the researcher. In addressing the question of whose meanings are represented in portraying children's games in ethnography, "insider accounts need to be balanced by observation as a major component of research" (K. Marsh, 2009, p. 97). The use of a range of data collection and interpretive measures is undertaken to achieve such balance.

In this article, I identify four of the documented games as exemplary of "multimodal musicality" and describe and analyze them to illustrate the complexity of children's musical play in urban South Africa.

Theoretical Framework

Musical Play and Multimodality

The portrayal and analysis of children's musical practices in this article draws on the multimodal framework (Jewitt, 2013; Jewitt & Kress, 2003; Kress, 2000c, 2010). As a "field of application rather than a theory" (Jewitt, 2010, p. 363), multimodality is based on theories of social semiotics. It concerns the representational and meaning-making potentials of communicative modes like speech, writing, image, movement, gesture, and sound (Jewitt & Kress, 2003; Kress, 2009, 2010; Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001; Stein, 2008), which are "socially shaped resources for making meaning" (Kress, 2011, p. 255).

I propose that the musicianship exhibited in children's musical games can best be examined by adopting a multimodal approach to analysis and interpretation. A multimodal reading provides insight into both the games' content and the inventive methods children employ in composition and performance. Although multimodality is applied to local practices here, I argue for its application in investigating the nature of children's musicality more broadly.

Acknowledging that musical play is by definition multimodal in content, a multimodal analytical approach is therefore appropriate (following Bishop & Burn, 2013). However, while studies usually focus on the multimodal *content* of musical games, my intention here is to hone in on a particular methodological dimension: children's deployment of resources in interesting and unique ways. This deployment relates closely to the concept of choice in multimodality (Kress, 2010), which in turn reflects children's identities and interests. Children's choices speak to their contexts; thus, the description and analysis demonstrates the especially vivid ways the games are locally and culturally coded.

The aim of this article is to contribute to the field by examining multimodality at work in four representative South African games, adding to an understanding of multimodality's relationship to musical play in this context.

The Shape of Multimodal Analysis

Multimodality is used here in several ways: as a descriptive category—musical play is multimodal in its combination of sound, movement, gesture, and language; as a field of enquiry—multimodality focuses on *how* meaning (or, in this case, music) is made; and as a methodological application—a multimodal approach "offers a systematic way of analyzing data" (Archer & Newfield, 2014, p. 1).

A multimodal perspective is adopted firstly because of its aptness for the research setting and ethnographic research (Kress, 2011); it is able to highlight the complexity of hybrid artistic and musical practices and the ways in which children incorporate media and cultural references in their musical games. Second, multimodality is "a key characteristic of musical play; children blend movement with singing. . . . They are therefore as visually and kinesthetically active as they are aurally" (Marsh & Young, 2006, p. 290). As both a concept and an analytical approach, multimodality is also increasingly used in music education (Pramling & Wallerstedt, 2009) and studies of musical play (Bishop & Burn, 2013; Countryman & Gabriel, 2014; Tomlinson, 2013, 2015).

Third, a multimodal analysis identifies the compositional *methods* children use in their musical games. Applying multimodality's conceptions of affordance, aptness, and semiotic resources (Kress, 2000c) facilitates an appreciation of the range of skills children display, notably the ability to mobilize multiple modes as resources for music-making. This process involves first children's recognition of the expressive potential of these modes and then their ability to appropriate and transform them for the purposes of musical play. A multimodal perspective therefore enables one to demonstrate the complex music, movement, and language content of children's games and *how* children are musical in creating them.

Finally, a multimodal perspective reveals the dominance of sound within the "multimodal ensemble" (Kress, 2000c). This dominance relates to the key concept of "affordance," which is the ability to recognize the unique expressive, representational, and communicative possibilities each mode offers (Gibson, 1977; Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001; Stein, 2008).[10] As will be shown, musicality resides in children's ability to recognize and exploit the musical qualities of other modes; in other words, they make linguistic and kinesthetic modes do musical work.

These musical games are thus multimodal in form, content, and compositional method. Although all the musical games documented display multimodality in all senses, the description of four games that follows is divided into different sections for analytical purposes. While all the games show a synchronisation of multiple modes, each demonstrates a different deployment of individual modes, how one mode is expressed as another, or where choices of modes as semiotic resources are prominent. Individual games also exemplify different forms of musical play like group circle or pair clapping games, those played only by boys or girls, and those they played together.

Clearly there is much "work" happening here in relation to children's identities and sociality; hence, the games can be read in multiple ways. The emphasis here is on how a multimodal lens uncovers the range of musical capacities the games exemplify and how it enables a reconception of children's musicianship as the capacity to "design" with multimodal resources.

Analysis

Musical Games as Multimodality in Action

The figure descriptions outline the text, sound, and accompanying movements to give a broad idea of each game. (Videos of each game are available at https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PLTjYEoLGspr6KJ81qUW2p7IxEW5a47bKX.) I selected the four following examples to highlight identifiable multimodal qualities: using words to create rhythms and sound effects and using gesture, language, and dance as semiotic resources. Accentuating these traits is intended to emphasize multimodal musicality in terms of both content and form.

Multimodal content: making modes do musical work. In the first two games, children capitalize on the aptness of language and movement (and their combinations) for creating rhythmic chants, clapping patterns, and playing "freeze" games. "Chocolatey" is a version of the classic musical statues game.

Words as rhythm: "Chocolatey." In a circle formation, a group of boys chant *choc-o-la-tey* in the syncopated, dotted rhythms of South African urban dance musics (see Figure 1). They freeze abruptly on "stop," pause, and do an extra jerky movement on "Don't move," holding their statue. The leader then shouts, "Change your style," whereupon everyone makes a contrasting statue (and a new one on the

Words	Movement & Actions	Sound
Cho-cola-tey, Chocolatey, Chocola-tey, Chocolatey.	Everyone dances in a circle to the chant's basic beat, with skipping-type steps.	Dotted rhythms, 4/4 time, rapid pulse-based chant The 1st "chocolatey" is chanted in a slow dotted rhythm; the 2nd doubles the time values of the 1st "chocolatey" rhythmic pattern
Stop! –	They all freeze like statues.	"Stop" is followed by a beat's rest
Don't move…. (leader) Change your style (leader) Another one …	Children in the group do two extra jerky movements and freeze again. Everyone changes their statue to create a new one Boys make a contrasting statue	The words "Don't move" are followed by beat's rest, during which new statues are made

Figure 1. Words, actions, and sounds of "Chocolatey" game.

instruction "another one"). Their poses are perfect pictures of stillness, of frozen kinetic movement.

The word *chocolatey* is used as a rhythmic idea rather than as a reference to chocolate. The syllables are broken up in two ways to produce contrasting syncopated, dotted rhythms in one phrase, which match the chant's dance movements. There is an interesting use of silence in the long pause after the words *stop* and *don't move*, during which children change their statues. The game illustrates children's expressive use of their bodies to capture style, fashion, and identity kinesthetically in their statues. In changing their "style," each participant makes new statues, attempting to be more unique than the others. The leader evaluates each statue by making comments and trying to make others laugh so that they move and are then out of the game.

Words as sound: "Tiny Thukhutela." Words similarly are used for their sonic affordances in "Tiny Thukutela," which is fast, frenetic, and loud. One child dances in the middle of a circle of boys and girls, who shout "*tiny, tiny thukhutela*," clapping to the chant's fast pulse (see Figure 2). The chant is pulse-based rather than metrical (in keeping with much African music). The *y* of *tiny* is drawn out over three pulses, and the next *tiny thukhutela* is chanted with two syllables to the pulse to create a fast syncopated rhythm.

In isiZulu, the verb *thukhutele* means "to be angry, annoyed or excited" (Doke, Malcolm, Sikakani, Vilakazi, & Khumalo, 1990, p. 805), and children said that *tiny thukhutela* meant that "the toy train goes faster." On the words *bantse ba re*, the child in the middle chooses and faces a partner in the circle, and they both jump back and forth twice together with both feet on the words *kushu kushu kushu*. On *turn-a morao* ("turn around"), they twirl around in unison, pivoting on one foot. Pairs watch each

Words	**Translation**	**Movements and actions**
Tiny – *Tiny thukhutela*	The toy train goes faster (*thukhutele* literally means 'angry' in *isiZulu*)	The child who is 'on' skips or walks quickly inside the circle, chanting and clapping to the pulse of the chant.
Tiny – *Tiny thukhutela*		
Bantse ba re	They keep on saying (in *Sesotho*)	The child who is 'on' approaches a partner and faces her.
Kushu kushu kushu	(Onomatopoeic words describing train sounds)	The *doh-soh* vocalisation matches jumping forwards and backwards facing a partner, with both feet.
Turn-a morao'	Turn around.	They both twirl around in unison.
Bantse ba re		
Turn-a morao'		

Figure 2. Words, translation, actions, and sounds of "Tiny Thukutela" game.

other closely, coordinating their movements precisely like a mirror dance. The game conveys the movements and sounds of a train, with the overall effect as one of kinetic energy and sound effects.

In terms of capitalizing on the affordances of language, the onomatopoeic words *kushu, kushu* illustrate train sounds while matching the forward and backward jumps. *Kushu* is chanted with the accent on *shu*, repeated in a dotted rhythm so that the *ku* is short and the *shu* longer; *ku* is lower, and *shu* is higher (sounding *doh, sol, doh, sol*). The word's tonal qualities are emphasized though pitching the two syllables. The word rhythm, chanted against the fast clapped pulse and combined with the rhythm of the pair movements, produces complex cross-rhythms. *Turna morau* is an adaption of "turn around," changed into Sesotho spelling while retaining the English words' sound. "Turn around" is augmented into four syllables instead of three—*turna morau*—to produce a four-note rhythm that matches the turning-around movement and follows the necessity to have an upbeat according to the chant's meter.

"Tiny Thukhutela" demonstrates children's recognition of the onomatopoeic, kinetic, and rhythmic affordances of language and how they combine these to create this fast game. When asked to explain the game, one child demonstrated its 'meaning' by rolling his hands and arms fast around each other (demonstrated on the video clip at the end of this performance). His response suggests a primary interest in the game's musical and kinetic "meaning" rather than semantics—that the significance of the game for children resides in synchronizing movements, pair interaction, and train sounds. Appreciating what language affords is not necessarily conscious for children, but it highlights their intuitive awareness of the musical qualities of language—"because it sounds nice," as one child explained. These two games illustrate that children's interest in "pure sound" coexists with their investment in music's relationship to nonmusical, personal, or social meaning.

Multimodal method: incorporating elements of the urban township. Multimodal richness is illustrated in the two following games that incorporate aspects of Soweto's urban township culture. The narrative clapping game "Banyana ke di bom bom" uses township communicative and representational practices to create texts concerning gender roles and identities.

Thus, language and gesture function here as semiotic resources. Children combine Sesotho with *scamto* slang and its accompanying gestural and postural language so that the relationship between words and gestures are exploited. In "Banyana ke di bom bom," children integrate gestures into a clapping pattern and chant words so that gestures, words, and their signification operate simultaneously.

Language and gestures as semiotic resource: "Banyana ke di bom bom." "Banyana ke di bom bom" combines pair cross-clapping with gestures that illustrate the actions or subtexts of *scamto* words (see Figure 3). Each clap corresponds to the five syllables of *banyana ke di*. Then, a gesture replaces a clap on the words *dekepis, dinkauza, cheeka*, and *kwai*. On the repeated words *kidi pom pom* (clapping pattern 2), a pat on the partner's chest replaces a clap on the second *pom*. Girls have to coordinate their movements and clapping carefully to make the patterns work. Each verse increases in tempo, thus incorporating an element of challenge that is a typical feature of children's musical games (K. Marsh, 2008).

Bom, bom—similar to the American slang *the bomb*—describes something that is the best of its kind. In terms of gestural signification, touching a partner's chest suggests that "both you and I are 'the bomb.'" As can be seen on the video clip, children explained that the game illustrates "things taking place in our families," with each verse describing a different person and his or her characteristic action. The references operate internally to *scamto* as practiced in Soweto. For example, a salute gesture references a boys' cap, and a smoking gesture represents men. The gesture of opening and closing one's hand near your mouth suggests talking loudly and also represents a mother figure in the game's context.

Here, children combine sound and movement in three ways. First, children use these combinations as social signifiers within a township context. Gestures can have double meanings, depending on their quality, girls' facial expressions, and nonverbal communication in individual performances. For example, the talking gesture either references a mother or alludes to gossiping. The smoking gesture signifies a cool male identity in the township or a *tsotsi* (gangster), explicitly referencing an aspect of urban culture.[11] *Kepis* indicates a young boy, while *kwai* signifies older boys or men and their possible sexual activity. Thus, the game plays with gestural meanings that are ambiguous in *scamto* communication. The meaning ascribed to *kwai*, as sexual or not, is codetermined by the movement associated with the smoking gesture so that semantics cannot be isolated from the actual performance and embodied interaction and communication between participants. This is clear on the video recording: girls laugh and giggle as they play the game, suggesting the possible transgressive nature of the words.

The second multimodal skill this game exemplifies is the ability to make gestures and movement work musically. Gestures replace claps on words like *dekepis* so that

Words	**Translation**	**Actions, gestures and sound**
Verse 1 *Banyana ke di bom bo*m	Girls are the 'bomb.'	Clapping pattern 1: pair clapping on the pulse of the chant: clap own hands; clap across to partner's left hand; clap own hands; clap across to partner's right hand; clap own hands; clap both palms of partner's hands, held vertically
Barata dekepis' (X2)	They wear caps.	Clapping pattern; gesture indicating wearing a hat on the word *kepis.*
Ke di bom bom, ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern 2 (very fast): on *ke di*, clap own hands, on the first *bom* clap both partner's hands, on the second *bom*, pat partner's chest (and repeat); the words "*bom, bom, ke di*" form a triplet rhythm.
Barata dekepis'		Clapping pattern one; gesture indicating a hat on *dekepis'*.
Ke di bom bom ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern 2
Barata dekepis'		Gesture indicating a hat on the word *kepis.*
Verse 2		
Bashimane ke di bom bom	Boys are 'bombs.'	Clapping pattern 1.
Barata dinkauza (X2)	They like cigarettes.	Gesture pretending to smoke on the word *kauza.*
Ke di bom bom ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern 2.
Barate dinkauza		Smoking gesture on *kauza.*
Ke di bom bom ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern 2.
Barata dinkauza		Smoking gesture on *kauza.*
Verse 3		
Bomme ke di bom bom	Mothers are the bomb.	Clapping pattern 1.
Barata go 'cheeka'	They like to shout.	On the word *cheeka*: hand gesture opening and closing fingers and thumb towards the mouth to indicate talking.
Ke di bom bom ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern 2.
Barata go 'cheeka'		*Cheeka* hand gesture as above
Ke di bom bom ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern as above.
Barata go 'cheeka'		*Cheeka* hand gesture as above
Verse 4		
Bontate ke di bom bom	Fathers are the bomb.	Clapping pattern 1.
Bontate de 'kwai' X2	They like tobacco/cigarettes (literal meaning)	Accompanied by an ambiguous sexual gesture, the meaning of which is unclear and elicits much giggling from the girls.
Ke di bom bom ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern 2.
Bontate de 'kwai'		'Cigarette smoking' gesture on '*kwai*'
Ke di bom bom ke di bom bom		Clapping pattern 2.
Bontate de 'kwai.'		

Figure 3. Words, translation, and actions of "Banyana ke di bom bom" game.

the cap action is integrated into the rhythm without disturbing the clapping pattern's tempo and flow. Each gesture becomes a musical "note" and is performed according to the word rhythm the gesture replaces. Keeping the rhythm going is paramount in the game because it enables successful pair clapping.

Third, combining gesture, clapping, and rhythmic chanting relates closely to children's cooperative musicality. Girls challenge each other to perform gestures very fast and are motivated to get it right according to the musical rules of the game. Such musical synchronization is a common feature of girls' pair clapping games, where they have no time to think whether the words they are chanting are sense or nonsense. They are concentrating all their energies on saying them in the right order and remembering the actions that go with them, driven by the need to keep in time with their partner (Opie & Opie, 1985/1988).

As may be viewed on the video recording, when asked questions, two girls explained how they create different actions and gestures according to what the games' participants like to do, composing further verses about family and friends for as long as they want to play. Hence, improvisation is a further musical capacity demonstrated here.

Language and dance as semiotic resource. In "Iskipa sika Jomo," children incorporate South African popular music-dance styles sourced from contemporary dance musics (*kwaito* and house), which themselves reference and transform earlier South African dance styles.[12] Children also emulate the mix-and-match practices of township youth culture, particularly popular music. Processes of appropriating and employing resources sourced from a range of contexts are typical traits of South African popular music genres more broadly (Allen, 2005). By using these practices, South African children reflect the way in which historical and contemporary popular music is composed.

What is significant is the way that "adult-generated sources of entertainment" are transferred to the playground and "subject to the creative endeavors of children" (K. Marsh & Young, 2006, 303). South African children's processes of appropriation echo those of children elsewhere: popular music and dance is not only copied but adapted to suit games like "Iskipa se ka Jomo." Such musical resources are used imaginatively as children recognize the semiotic potential of dance styles to reference the adult world, sexuality, urban culture, and identities.

"Iskipa sika Jomo." Boys and girls play the circle game "Iskipa" together. The child who is "on" dances inside the circle as the group chants *Iskipa sika Jomo esibalwe u seven siyangchaza* in a dotted, syncopated rhythm and slow tempo reminiscent of 1990s *kwaito* rap (see Figure 4). On the words *wang 'bamba*, a little girl skips toward a partner, faces her, and holds onto her shoulders, waist, and hips, timing her actions with the corresponding words of the chant.

The game's dance-touch actions are reminiscent of a well-known South African 1950s urban pair dance style called *patha-patha* ("touch touch"). Pair actions are

Words	**Translation**	**Movements and actions**
Iskipa sika Jomo	Jomo's T-shirt,	The group chants the words in a dotted rhythm, while one child claps on the beat and walks around inside the circle.
Esibalwe u seven'	that is printed with the number seven,	
Siyangchaza (repeated twice)	We like it.	
Wang 'bamba'mahlombe	You hold me on the shoulders.	S/he chooses a partner and holds onto or touches each body part mentioned in the chant, starting with their shoulders.
Wang'bamba 'mafiga	You hold me on the waist. ("*Figa*" is a modification of the English 'figure' and indicates a desirable female figure in township *scamto*.	The child who is 'on' holds their partner around their waist
Wang'bamba 'mahips	You hold me on the hips.	Touching partner's hips
Kan'ung'bamba kanjani?	IsiZulu for "How will you hold me?"	Shouted in unison with a strong emphasis on vowel tonal qualities

Figure 4. Words, translation, and actions of "Iskipa sika Jomo" game.

performed with corresponding words that describe each part of the body, each with a different pitch: *mahlombe* starts low, *mafiga* gets higher, and eventually children accentuate *hips* by making the word much higher in pitch and louder, highlighting the word's sexual connotations. They shout the last phrase, *kan'i ung'bamba kanjani* ("how do you hold me!") in unison, exaggerating the words' rhythmic and tonal qualities, which emphasizes the suggestiveness of the statement. Using the tonal qualities of South African languages for expressive (and musical) purposes illustrates children's recognition of what language can afford. These particular children whose game was video-recorded, (and who were in Grade 4, aged between 8 and 10) clearly enjoy the phrase's implied transgression (sexual contact with a boy or girl). What is fascinating is the extent to which word connotations relate closely to the nature of the movements and pair interactions. Semantics depend on performance; the meanings of the words rely on kinesthetic qualities.

Last, the choice of *patha patha* as a dance and musical style is significant as it references a history of township urban popular music and dance that has been incorporated into later popular music styles. *Patha patha* bespeaks an urban South African identity and as an adult dance suggests children's curiosity and exploration of different gender roles. "Iskipa" epitomizes how children appropriate elements from adult culture and play with them in a musical game. In combining the signifying potential of dance and touching actions, the energy of syncopated rhythms and the expressive, musical

affordances of *scamto* and *Nguni* languages, "Iskipa se ka Jomo" embodies multimodality in action.

Musical Collaboration and Modes in Combination

The separation of modes in the previous analyses is intended to highlight specific multimodal capacities at work. However, in performance, it is striking to see (and hear) how children show musical and kinesthetic skills concurrently. While there may be a dominance of, for example, word–sound association, there is usually a complex use of language, movement, and rhythm operating simultaneously in one game.

The way that modes are used in conjunction represents forms of learning that entail sensory integration as well as musical skills. In "Tiny Thukutela," for example, children are able to chant words rhythmically with the group while doing jumping steps in unison with a partner that produce cross-rhythms with the chant's rhythm. In "Chocolatey," children make a range of body sculptures, clap the beat, and chant word rhythms that produce a *kwaito* rhythm in cross-rhythm with their dance steps.

The multimodal nature of musical games also presupposes cooperation. In "Banyana ke di bom bom," careful musical and physical cooperation is required to integrate the gesture into the chant's rhythm and clapping pattern as well as perform the "touch" action together and in time with a partner (particularly given the game's rapid tempo). Unison performances like these necessitate a distinctive kind of musical and kinetic collaboration as the clapping shifts between rhythmic accentuation and marking the pulse.

Global Traits: Mobilizing Multiple Resources

Musical and kinetic collaboration is perhaps the most prominent universal feature of musical games (see J. Marsh & Richards, 2013). While the content of the games is local in this study, the common element of cooperation is demonstrated as a key skill related to utilizing music, dance, and linguistic elements for the purposes of musical play.

Children's method of appropriating material for integration into existing musical games or for creating new ones is recognized also as a universal trait (Factor, 2001; Harwood, 1994; J. Marsh & Richards, 2013; K. Marsh, 2001, 2008). As K. Marsh and Young (2006) confirm, "what is striking in all contexts is how children actively create their own opportunities for playful musical activity from what is available" (p. 294). Critically though, the appropriation and incorporation process can be both imitative and innovative. Children "play around with texts, movements, melodies and rhythms" (K. Marsh, 2008, p. 262), adapting them to be interesting or amusing. In "Iskipa," for example, the *patha patha* dance is not only emulated but also is adapted to communicate the game's *scamto* words. The movements in conjunction the words' tonal qualities are exaggerated to parody an adult dance style.

Hence, musical games are "generative practices" (K. Marsh & Young, 2006, p. 302), where addition, adaptation, and improvisation are integral to playing

well-known games or to invent ideas for new games. The fluid nature of musical games links closely with a further shared stylistic feature: Children stamp their own identity on an existing game. These processes are improvisatory, as new additions often are made during performance on the playground. In "Chocolatey," township children keep creating new body sculptures to outdo one another; in "Banyana," extra verses are added by individual performers, who teach the new verses to others as they are playing. Transforming existing games or using familiar material and formulae to create new ones are among "a number of musical, textual and movement characteristics [that] appear to transcend cultural boundaries" (K. Marsh & Young, 2006, p. 302). These abilities underline children's resourcefulness as a key component of multimodal musicality.

Implications of Children's Multimodal Musicality for Music Education

Musical Learning as Design

From a multimodal perspective, resourcefulness is the ability to recognize and capitalize on the affordances of different modes. It implies recognizing the potential or "perceived action possibilities" posed by the environment or objects in the environment and then acting in accordance with this potential to "transform affordances into action" (Gee, n.d., p. 9). These elements of learning are key ingredients of "learning as design" as proposed in the related fields of multimodality and the multiliteracies pedagogy (Kress, 2000b; New London Group, 2000).

When applied to musical ability, a conception of learning as *design* is useful because the word implies "both creating and working in its etymology" (Kress, 2000b, p. 143). Children's design capacity is understood as their ability to choose and shape material effectively for expressive, performative, or representational purposes (Stein, 2008). Musical designing, then, implies drawing on and organizing movement, verbal, and sonic materials into sound designs. It suggests that musical learning may comprise the capacity to be increasingly effective in transforming affordances of different modes into music-making.

When design in Kress's sense is applied to music education, it proposes a conception of musicality that is more than learning a set of skills or musical knowledges through acquisition. Music-making as designing characterizes performers and creators as resourceful. This is because designing in the multimodality framework "rests on agency; it takes agency for granted, still as work, no longer as acquisition, but now definitely as 'shaping work'" (Kress, 2000a, p. 141).

Designing with sound rather than learning a musical orthodoxy or literacy relates to music-making as an active process of shaping and transforming musical materials for specific purposes. Applying the concept of learning as design to children's musicking enables an understanding of the action and creativity inherent in agency. The sense of personal agency exemplified in children's control of resources and design capacity in their musical play can be capitalized on in music education.

Recruiting Children's Musical Games as Resources for Pedagogy

Multimodal analysis highlights children's musical games as generative activities that draw attention to "multimodal meaning-making outside formal contexts" (Stein, 2008, p. 142). It further reveals the potential of musical games as resources for pedagogy—their capacity for "recruitment" in music education in order to develop the musical design abilities the games demonstrate.

Musical play research confirms that "knowing how children play, and play musically, offers important perspectives . . . which can help teachers design and deliver relevant and meaningful lessons" (Lew & Campbell, 2005, pp. 58–59). Similarly, Lum and Campbell (2007) emphasize the fact that in "designing and delivering instruction," music education needs to move from "where [children] are, to new realms of musical experience, in order to *be* educational" (p. 46). This suggests that repeating musical games in the classroom does not go far enough. What is needed is a teaching *methodology* for delivering curricula based on insights from children's musical play, which is mostly absent in the literature (a notable exception being Harwood & Marsh, 2012).

Music education research in Africa considers the relationship between children's music and the classroom, emphasizing the cultural relevance and socially educative content of indigenous games and songs (Abarry, 1989; Addo, 1997; Akuno, 1997; Dzansi, 2002; Makina, 2009; Mapana, 2011; Marfo & Biersteker, 2011; Nyota & Mapara, 2008). The tendency is to interpret the implications of children's play for classroom practice on the level of "cultural relevance" as ways of teaching indigenous content (Dzansi, 2004), for "social education" (Nyota & Mapara, 2008), or to teach curricula learning outcomes (Roux, Burnett, & Hollander, 2008). This research suggests a reiteration of the games rather than considering the forms of musical learning implied in their practice.

The absence of a teaching methodology for connecting musical learning inside and outside the classroom is argued cogently by Green (2005):

> Attempts have been made in many countries to close the gap between two musical worlds: that of pupils' musical culture outside school, and that of the classroom. However, whilst the former musical world, represented by various popular musics, now makes up a major part of curriculum content, the informal learning practices of the musicians who create these musics have not normally been recognized or adopted as teaching and learning strategies within classrooms. (2005, p. 27)

Mans (2003) makes a related point by advocating "an increased use of play . . . not only as content, but as the form of all musical learning activities" (p. 195). In keeping with these arguments, I contend that transferring musical games from the playground to the classroom does not constitute new learning because it does not develop the skills children demonstrate in their games.[13] The idea of recruiting musical games for formal learning is therefore significant: *Recruitment* suggests that the musical design abilities, forms of learning, musical content, and capacities inherent in musical play can be harnessed to create new learning.

The concept of recruitment is articulated in the multiliteracies pedagogy, which provides a methodology for incorporating children's musical games in teaching and learning so that their potential is realized (Cope & Kalantzis, 2000; New London Group, 2000). The multiliteracies pedagogy proposes a method for moving teaching and learning through four processes. The capacities exemplified in children's "Situated Practices" (their musical games), are combined with new learning the teacher introduces in "Overt Instruction" and through moments of reflection in "Critical Framing" produces "Transformed Practice": the application of prior and new skills and knowledge to new creative contexts (Cope & Kalantzis, 2000, p. 241).

Working with the children who played these games in Soweto primary schools, their teachers and I introduced the multiliteracies pedagogy as a pedagogic innovation over four months during their arts and culture lessons. Drawing on children's multimodal design capacities and the multimodal resources of their games, children applied the new skills and ideas learned from teachers in Overt Instruction to create new collaborative games and rhythmic poems in Transformed Practice. The research confirmed how the multiliteracies pedagogy provides a way of accessing and utilizing children's musical practices and abilities to create new learning in new artistic or musical contexts. It is thus pedagogy for transformation rather than reiteration.

Applying this pedagogy in Soweto schools demonstrated the potential for music education to become a more creative process built on children's agency. It further responded to some of the challenges and contradictions of South African music education by proposing a teaching methodology that acknowledges specific musical and educational contexts. Connecting children's informal musical learning to formal teaching in this way also addressed the dislocation between South African classrooms and playgrounds. This is because the process of recognition, inclusion, and development implied in the multiliteracies pedagogy assists children to access curriculum knowledge when such connections are made (Harrop-Allin, 2014b).

Although this research is located in and responds to a South African educational and musical context, I suggest it has broader application. As a global phenomenon, the multimodal musicality discussed here in South African examples is likely to be present in most children's musical games (as confirmed by Bishop & Burn, 2013). Possibilities for recruiting these as resources for pedagogy therefore exist in any educational environment as the multiliteracies pedagogy acknowledges context by accessing learners' "situated practices." This pedagogy is therefore productive for a music education that acknowledges that all children are musical. It provides the method for extending children's musicality in meaningful ways through connecting to their musical identities, abilities, and practices.

Prior to implementing any pedagogy though, educators need to understand the nature and textures of children's "innate" musicality (in this case, exemplified in their musical games). Multimodal analysis is a useful means to do so as it provides certain productive ways of interpreting the practices into the classroom. Such analysis demonstrates children's musicality as multimodal—as the ability to mobilize multimodal

resources to invent and reinvent musical games. Applying multimodality theory to children's musicking can create an expanded view of musicality that is more than learning musical skills to include being resourceful in relation to musical design. By viewing children as musically agentive, we may begin to focus on how to harness their multimodal capacities in music education more broadly to develop the creative inventiveness children display in their musical play.

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Notes

1. For examples, see Harwood (1998), J. Marsh and Hallett (2000), Campbell (2002), Mans (2003), Dzansi (2004), Barrett (2005), Davis (2005), Lew and Campbell (2005), Temmerman (2005), Jaffurs (2006), K. Marsh and Young (2006), Lum and Campbell (2007), K. Marsh (2008), Andang'o (2009), Harrop-Allin (2011, 2014a, 2014b), Koops (2010), and Harwood and Marsh (2012).
2. A township in South Africa is an urban area segregated from White cities and towns, historically demarcated for Blacks under apartheid legislation. Although this is no longer the case post-1994, areas like Soweto remain largely Black or mixed-race.
3. *Loxion kulcha* means literally "location culture" and references a clothing brand and post-apartheid township youth style (Bogatsu, 2002). *Loxion kulcha* originated post-liberation (1994) as "an alternative narrative of the new South Africa. Black urban youth started to express their experience in a conglomeration of practices that has come to be known as 'Y culture' or *loxion kulcha*" (Allen, 2004, p. 83). Historically, the pejorative word *location* describes any South African township. The words *kasie, ekas*, or *loxion* are "common in black colloquial speech today" as an ironic reference to the original meaning of *location* (Coplan, 2007, p. 444).
4. *Scamto* is a "contemporary African urban slang, based on a mixture of Afrikaans, 'township' Zulu, Sotho and English" (Coplan, 2007, p. 440) (see also Motshega, 2005). It has become a *lingua franca* in urban areas and is primarily a marker of urban identity (Ntshangase, 2002).
5. *Kwaito* is a South African form of electronic dance music that emerged post-1994, which "expressed the aspirations and experience of urban black youth, particularly in Gauteng" (Allen, 2004, p. 85). Musically, *kwaito* is "composed of slowed-down house tracks and repetitive 'chanted' lyrics in Zulu, English or *scamto*" (Steingo, 2007, p. 23).
6. Education levels in the majority (but not all) of South African government schools, particularly in literacy and numeracy, are arguably worse than they were under apartheid (Bloch,

2009; Department of Education, 2003, 2004, 2009; Fleisch, 2008; Howie, van Staden, Tshele, Dowse, & Zimmerman, 2012; Spreen & Vally, 2010). The situation is very different in resourced schools. Music and arts education is both present and substantial in most South African private schools or in good government schools that were historically for Whites (but now open to all). In historically "Black" and rural schools, poorly trained teachers experience challenges implementing "Creative and Performing Arts" in the Curriculum Assessment Policy Statement (CAPS) curriculum (Department of Education, 2011) and the Revised National Curriculum Statement before it (Department of Education, 2002).

7. Each school shared similar demographics as former "Black township" schools (under apartheid education policies). Although South Africa's education system is now officially deracialized, township schools remain predominantly for Black children by virtue of their geographical situation as well as other socioeconomic, political, and historical factors.
8. As a South African music educator involved in teacher training, community music, and development projects (mainly in Soweto) for over 20 years, I was familiar with and able to access the research sites in primary schools. The teachers at these schools also had previously received in-service training through a university arts education diploma course that I taught.
9. Code-switching is a linguistic practice of switching languages and linguistic varieties in the same conversation and is a typical feature of South African townships (Slabbert & Finlayson, 2002).
10. In music studies, the concept of affordance is used by DeNora (2000), Eric Clarke (2005), and especially by Theo Van Leeuwen (1999) in investigating the nature of musical meaning.
11. The word *tsotsi* refers to a young man who is a stylish, streetwise gangster (Glaser, 2000). The township gangster embodies the *tsotsi* style of the 1950s associated with Sophiatown and *kwela* music (Allen, 1999; Coplan, 2007). As a signifier of social, cultural capital in the township context, the *tsotsi* and *pantsula* images endure in local music and dance forms such as *kwaito*.
12. These include South African urban dance styles *kwassa* and *patha patha*. *Patha patha* developed in Sophiatown in the 1950s to 1960s and is particularly associated with Dorothy Masuka's song of the same name, made internationally famous by Miriam Makeba (Lara Allen, personal communication, 2010). It is "an individualized, sexually suggestive form of jive dancing for young people in which partners alternately touched each other all over the body with their hands, in time with the rhythm" (Coplan, 2007, p. 192). *Kwassa* is based on the Congolese *ndombolo* dance style and "is now a local South African dance on its own popularized in a popular song music video by Abashante lead singer Iyaya" (Coplan, 2002, p. 110).
13. Folklorists and music educators identify the potential problems of directly appropriating children's musical play and games as classroom materials (K. Marsh, 2008; see also Harwood, 1994; Merrill-Mirsky, 1988).

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